

Plato and the Socratic dialogues



Statues of Socrates (left) and Plato at the Academy of Arts in Athens.

Since Socrates wrote nothing himself, almost everything we know about his philosophy comes from the works of his protégé Plato. Fortunately, nearly all of Plato's prolific writings have survived, and Socrates figures largely in many of them. As well as accounts of Socrates's ideas, such as the description of his trial in the *Apologia* (see [The life unexamined](#)), Plato embraced his mentor's idea of the dialectic and presented a large number of his philosophical works in the form of dialogues. In most of these, Socrates

appears as the principal character, quizzing other philosophers and public figures.

These ‘Socratic dialogues’ present us with a problem, however: Plato is effectively putting words into the mouths of his characters – so how much of the philosophy underlying them is Socrates, and how much Plato? Fortunately, Plato left us enough work that is clearly his own to get a good idea of his original ideas, but Socrates’s influence on him was enormous, and it is not always easy to distinguish the two.